



FB's new project

Facebook launches Internet.org to make Internet access cheaper globally. <http://dgit.in/12o6wCL>

Touchscreen Laptops Test

HOW WE TESTED

We never benchmark a laptop's performance with the way the OS and the software is, out of the box. We uninstall all software that are preloaded on the machine, including any security software trials and other bloatware - to ensure none of the pre-bundled software has any effect on the laptop's performance score. We then download and install the latest patches and drivers from Windows Update or the manufacturer website, BIOS update and any critical patches the manufacturer may have released.

Benchmarking

We run a range of industry standard software benchmarks to measure a laptop's hardware

capability and overall performance - PC Mark 07, Cinebench R11.5 and 3D Mark 11 and Unigine Heaven are some examples of the benchmarks that we use to test and compare laptops with. We have added a series of tests for the display quality too, to test aspects like contrast, black and white levels through Lagom.nl. Battery tests are done on high-performance mode with full screen brightness.

Ergonomics

While look and feel can be a matter of personal preference to some extent, determining the best ergonomic design is a matter of scientific principles. In determining the Design & Usability

score for every laptop, we take into account several factors like build quality, materials used, quality and placement of hinges, keyboard usage quality and feel as well as the comfort, palmrest real estate, touchpad response quality, etc., and break it down exhaustively to arrive at a cumulative score for ergonomics, design and general usability aspects of the laptop. After going through this process for each and every laptop, we arrive at a final score based on a formula with assigned weighted scores for performance, design, and features. The Best Performer Award is given to the best performing laptop across categories, whereas Best Buys are confined within price-based categories.

Agreed that the Windows 8 UI is meant for touch, but for anyone who is going to use Windows 8 in the desktop mode, much like the way he/she used Windows 7, then a touchscreen hardly makes any sense. While glittering ads and persuasive brands will have you believe that a touchscreen is a "must" on a Windows 8 laptop, that is hardly the case. The good old touchpad and keyboard still do the job as well as ever.

But what about everyone out there interested in buying a touch-enabled laptop? Read on.

TOUCHSCREENS

The screen sizes vary between the odd 11-inch, 13-inch and even 15-inches across this test. All touchscreens supported 10-point multi-touch input, and there wasn't much to separate

them in terms of smooth and consistent response. The critical factor in the touchscreen experience is the deployment of the screen and how taut the lid is, to prevent it from rocking every time you touch it.

HP ENVY TouchSmart 11

This is the most affordable ultrabook in the test and a successor to the Pavilion dm1 range of notebooks. Between this and the bigger ENVY notebooks, there really isn't much difference in terms of the look, design, build quality and the materials used. Except that the lid hinge design and the bulbous battery design below the display. But, mind you, they don't get in the way, and the silver finish on an otherwise black coloured laptop adds a subtle contrast. The lid, with the grey enamel finish, looks very similar to the ones found on the HP Mini range of netbooks. For a small sized machine, the TouchSmart 11 still packs in three USB ports, memory card reader and an HDMI out. What we are most impressed about is the quality of finish on an affordable notebook. The small size and

the 1.4kg weight makes this supremely portable.

The keyboard design and layout is exactly as the ones on the much bigger ENVY notebooks, and offers the same "MacBook-ish" precision and experience, which is by far the best among all the affordable notebooks. To fit this in the dimensions, the key size is smaller, but the key spacing and response are as good as ever.

In terms of performance, the AMD dual core A4-1250 clocking at 1GHz does fall slightly behind the Intel Core i3-3217U found in the slightly more expensive Asus F202e. However, while the boot times are slightly on the higher side, the TouchSmart 11 did not freeze or slow down when used for basic tasks and a bit of multi-tasking - and that is all this machine is meant to do. The Radeon HD 8250 graphics are only marginally better than the Intel HD 4000 graphics on the Asus F202e, but that is not a huge consideration.

The 11.6-inch touchscreen display is pretty much at par in terms of crispness and colour reproduction as the F202e's screen. However, black level

depth was better in the latter, something that shows up on the TouchSmart's 11-inch display when you turn up the brightness above 60%, and the blacks look like dark greys.

However, where the TouchSmart 11 really needs to be praised is for the battery life. In our battery tests, this machine clocked 248 minutes, which easily translates into the ultrabook-ish 6 hours of battery life under most usage scenarios. A rather impressive package at an affordable price tag.

Asus VivoBook F202e

For an 11.6-inch display size device, the F202E is compact. It is slightly thicker at the back and thinner at the front, lending the keyboard a slight incline which really helps while typing. The lid has the traditional brushed metal look we have seen on much more expensive Asus ultr-



HP ENVY 11 TouchSmart



Asus VivoBook F202e

